If virtue is examined in terms of an individual's life, is our pursuit of the good life an egoistic one? Aristotle proposes that what is good for one person may also benefit others. Since by nature, we are social (sometimes translated as political) beings, we need friends. When we live with fine friends who take fine actions, our virtues remain active and we receive "training in virtue" (1170a10). This explains the theme we ascribe to our selection, "Friendship and Happiness".

Reading Aristotle after Plato's dramatic dialogue, we leap into a stylistically different world. While Plato's *Symposium* is marked by its lively characterization and literary expression, Aristotle, in the *Nicomachean Ethics*, presents his ideas in prose, which typically takes us from some common beliefs or puzzling phenomena to a set of questions and their explication, and eventually resolving them. As you walk through Aristotle's path, feel for yourself its grain and texture, and decide for yourself if it is the good that you would seek.

The translation we use is by J.A.K. Thomson. It is chosen primarily because of its accessibility to modern readers.

Yeung Yang

from

Nicomachean Ethics

by Aristotle

I
THE OBJECT OF LIFE

i.

Every rational activity aims at some end or good.
One end (like one activity) may be
subordinate to another

1094a

Every art and every investigation, and similarly every action and pursuit, is considered to aim at some good. Hence the good has been rightly defined as "that at which all things aim". Clearly, however, there is some difference between the ends at which they aim: some are activities and others results distinct from the activities. Where there are ends distinct from the actions, the results are by nature superior to the activities. Since there are many actions, arts and sciences, it follows that their ends are many too—the end of medical science is health; of military science, victory; of economic science,[1] wealth. In the case of all skills of this kind that come under

[1] i.e. household or property management.

From *The Nicomachean Ethics*, translated by J. A. K. Thomson, revised with notes and appendcies by Hugh Tredennick (Penguin Classics 1955, Revised edition 1976). Reproduced by permission of Penguin Books Ltd.

a single faculty—as a skill in making bridles or any other part of a horse's trappings comes under horsemanship, while this and every kind of military action comes under military science, so in the same way other skills are subordinate to yet others—in all these the ends of the directive arts are to be preferred in every case to those of the subordinate ones, because it is for the sake of the former that the latter are pursued also. It makes no difference whether the ends of the actions are the activities themselves or something apart from them, as in the case of the sciences we have mentioned.

If, then, our activities have some end which we want for its own sake, and for the sake of which we want all the other ends—if we do not choose everything for the sake of something else (for this will involve an infinite progression, so that our aim will be pointless and ineffectual)—it is clear that this must be the good, that is, the supreme good. Does it not follow, then, that a knowledge of the good is of great importance to us for the conduct of our lives? Are we not more likely to achieve our aim if we have a target? If this is so, we must try to describe at least in outline what the good really is, and by which of the sciences or faculties[2] it is studied.

[. . .]

v.

The three types of life. Neither pleasure nor public honour seems to be an adequate end; the contemplative life will be considered later

(1095b) But let us resume from the point at which we digressed. To judge by their lives, the masses and the most vulgar seem—not unreasonably—to believe that the good or happiness is pleasure. Accordingly they ask for nothing better than the life of enjoyment. (Broadly speaking, there are three main types of life: the one just mentioned, the political and, thirdly, the contemplative.[3]) The utter servility of the masses comes out in their preference for a bovine existence; still, their view

[2] Here "faculty" (*dunamis*) means "art" or "practical science".

[3] Cf. Plato, *Republic* 581C; the division is attributed to Pythagoras.

obtains consideration from the fact that many of those who are in positions of power share the tastes of Sardanapalus.[4] Cultured people, however, and men of affairs identify the good with honour, because this is (broadly speaking) the goal of political life. Yet it appears to be too superficial to be the required answer. Honour is felt to depend more on those who confer than on him who receives it; and we feel instinctively that the good is something proper to its possessor and not easily taken from him. Again, people seem to seek honour in order to convince themselves of their own goodness; at any rate it is by intelligent men, and in a community where they are known, and for their goodness, that they seek to be honoured; so evidently in their view goodness is superior to honour. One might even be inclined to suppose that goodness rather than honour is the end pursued in public life. But even this appears to be somewhat deficient as an end, because the possession of goodness is thought to be compatible even with being asleep, or with leading a life of inactivity, and also with incurring the most atrocious suffering and misfortune; and nobody would call such a life happy—unless he was defending a paradox.[5] So much for these views: they have been fully treated in current discussions.[6] The third type of life is the contemplative, and this we shall examine later.[7]

As for the life of the businessman, it does not give him much freedom of action. Besides, wealth is obviously not the good that we are seeking, because it serves only as a means; i.e. for getting something else. Hence the earlier suggestions might be supposed to be more likely ends, because they are appreciated on their own account; but evidently they too are inadequate, and many attacks on them have been published.[8] Let them therefore be dismissed.

[. . .]

[4] An Assyrian king of legendary sensuality.

[5] A *thesis*, i.e. a paradoxical generalization by a leading philosopher; cf. *Topics* 104b19–28, where examples are quoted.

[6] Apparently at a popular level.

[7] In Book X.

[8] Following the reading of the best Greek manuscripts.

vii.

What is the good for man? It must be the ultimate end or object of human life: something that is in itself completely satisfying. Happiness fits this description

(1097a) 15 Let us now turn back again to the good which is the object of our search, and ask what it can possibly be; because it appears to vary with the action or art. It is one thing in medicine and another in strategy, and similarly in all the other sciences. What, then, is the good of each particular one? Surely it is that for the sake of which everything else is done. In medicine this is health; in strategy, victory; 20 in architecture, a building—different things in different arts, but in every action and pursuit it is the *end*, since it is for the sake of this that everything else is done. Consequently if there is any one thing that is the end of all actions, this will be the practical good—or goods, if there are more than one. Thus while changing its ground the argument has reached the same conclusion as before.[9]

25 We must try, however, to make our meaning still clearer. Since there are evidently more ends than one, and of these we choose some (e.g. wealth or musical instruments or tools generally) as means to something else, it is clear that not all of them are final ends, whereas the supreme good is obviously something final. So if there is only one final end, this will be the good of which we are in search; 30 and if there are more than one, it will be the most final of these. Now we call an object pursued for its own sake more final than one pursued because of something else, and one which is never choosable because of another more final than those which are choosable because of it as well as for their own sakes; and that which is always choosable for its own sake and never because of something else we call final without any qualification.

Well, happiness more than anything else is thought to be just such an end, 1097b because we always choose it for itself, and never for any other reason. It is different with honour, pleasure, intelligence and good qualities[10] generally. We do choose them partly for themselves (because we should choose each one of them

[9] See 1094a18–22.
[10] Or "virtues".

irrespectively of any consequences); but we choose them also for the sake of our happiness, in the belief that they will be instrumental in promoting it. On the other 5 hand nobody chooses happiness for *their* sake, or in general for any other reason.

The same conclusion seems to follow from another consideration. It is a generally accepted view that the perfect good is self-sufficient. By self-sufficient we mean not what is sufficient for oneself alone living a solitary life,[11] but something that includes parents, wife and children, friends and fellow-citizens in 10 general; for man is by nature a social being. (We must set some limit to these, for if we extend the application to grandparents and grandchildren and friends of friends it will proceed to infinity; but we must consider this point later.[12]) A self-sufficient thing, then, we take to be one which by itself makes life desirable[13] and in no way 15 deficient; and we believe that happiness is such a thing. What is more, we regard it as the most desirable of all things, not reckoned as one item among many; if it were so reckoned, happiness would obviously be more desirable by the addition of even the least good, because the addition makes the sum of goods greater, and the greater of two goods is always more desirable. Happiness, then, is found to be something 20 perfect and self-sufficient, being the end to which our actions are directed.

But what is happiness? If we consider what the function of man is, we find that happiness is a virtuous activity of the soul

But presumably to say that happiness is the supreme good seems a platitude, and some more distinctive account of it is still required. This might perhaps be achieved by grasping what is the function of man. If we take a flautist[14] or a sculptor or any 25 artist—or in general any class of men who have a specific function or activity—his goodness and proficiency are considered to lie in the performance of that function; and the same will be true of man, assuming that man has a function. But is it likely

[11] The Greek word (*autarkēs*) normally carries the sense of independence.
[12] See 1100a10–1101a21.
[13] Here and in the following lines the meaning is really "choosable", *hairetos*.
[14] The Greek *aulos* was not a flute but a reed instrument.

that whereas joiners and shoemakers have certain functions or activities, man as such has none, but has been left by nature a functionless being? Just as we can see that eye and hand and foot and every one of our members have some function, should we not assume that in like manner a human being has a function over and above these particular functions? What, then, can this possibly be? Clearly life is a thing shared also by plants, and we are looking for man's *proper* function; so we must exclude from our definition the life that consists in nutrition and growth. Next in order would be a sort of sentient life; but this too we see is shared by horses and cattle and animals of all kinds. There remains, then, a practical life of the rational[15] part. (This has two aspects: one amenable to reason, the other possessing it and initiating thought.[16]) As this life also has two meanings, we must lay down that we intend here life determined by activity, because this is accepted as the stricter sense.[17] Now, if the function of man is an activity of the soul in accordance with, or implying, a rational principle; and if we hold that the function of an individual and of a good individual of the same kind—e.g. of a harpist and of a good harpist and so on generally—is generically the same, the latter's distinctive excellence being attached to the name of the function (because the function of the harpist is to play the harp, but that of the good harpist is to play it well); and if we assume that the function of man is a kind of life, namely, an activity or series of actions of the soul, implying a rational principle; and if the function of a good man is to perform these well and rightly; and if every function is performed well when performed in accordance with its proper excellence: if all this is so, the conclusion is that the good for man is an activity of the soul in accordance with virtue, or if there are more kinds of virtue than one, in accordance with the best and most perfect kind.

There is a further qualification: in a complete lifetime. One swallow does not make a summer; neither does one day. Similarly neither can one day, or a brief space of time, make a man blessed and happy.

[. . .]

[15] See 1102b32n.
[16] This comment is irrelevant here; it anticipates the discussion at 1102b25–33.
[17] The other being life as a *state*, implying no more than the possession of reason. [. . .]

VIII
THE KINDS OF FRIENDSHIP

i.
Friendship is a necessity

After this the next step will be to discuss friendship; for it is a kind of virtue, or implies virtue, and it is also most necessary for living. Nobody would choose to live without friends even if he had all the other good things. Indeed those who hold wealth and office and power are thought to stand in special need of friends; for what is the use of such prosperity to them if they are denied the opportunity for beneficence, which is most commonly and most commendably directed towards friends? Or how can their prosperity be guarded and preserved without friends? because the greater it is, the more precarious. In poverty too and all the other misfortunes of life people regard their friends as their only refuge. Friends are indeed a help both to the young, in keeping them from mistakes; and to the old, in caring for them and doing for them what through frailty they cannot do for themselves; and to those in the prime of life, by enabling them to carry out fine achievements: "When two together go"[18] they are better able both to see an opportunity and to take it. And the affection of parent for child and of child for parent seems to be a natural instinct not only in man but in birds and most animals; and similarly the mutual friendliness between members of the same species, especially of the human species; which is why we commend those who love their fellowmen. One can see also in one's travels how near and dear a thing every man is to every other. Friendship also seems to be the bond that holds communities together, and lawgivers seem to attach more importance to it than to justice; because concord seems to be something like friendship, and concord is their primary object—that and eliminating faction, which is enmity. Between friends there is no need for justice, but people who are just still need the quality of friendship; and indeed friendliness is considered to be justice in the fullest sense. It is not only a necessary thing but a splendid one. We praise

1098a 5 10 15 20 30

1155a 5 10 15 20 25

[18] Homer, *Iliad* x.224.

those who love their friends, and the possession of many friends is held to be one of the fine things of life. What is more, people think that good men and friends are the same.[19]

[. . .]

ii.

The objects and implications of affection

(1155b) Perhaps it will throw light on the subject if we get a clear conception of what an object of affection is. It is generally accepted that not everything is loved, but only what is lovable; and that this is either good, or pleasant or useful. But it may be thought that "useful" means nothing more than "productive of some good or pleasure"; so that the only objects of love that are *ends* would be the good and the pleasant. Is it, then, the good that people love, or only what is good *for them*? because sometimes these conflict; and similarly in the case of the pleasant. It seems that each individual loves what is good for himself; i.e. that while the good is absolutely lovable, it is the good of the individual that is lovable for the individual. But the individual loves not what *is* good for him but what *appears* to be such. However, this will not affect the argument: the lovable will be what appears to be lovable.

Let us assume, then, that there are three reasons for loving. We do not speak of friendship in the case of our affection for inanimate objects, because there is no return of affection, and no wish for the good of the object (for presumably it would be absurd for a person to wish for the good of his wine; if he has any wish it is that the wine may keep, so that he may have it himself). But in the case of a friend they say that one ought to wish him good for his own sake. Those who wish for the well-being of others in this way are called well disposed if the same feeling is not evoked from the other party, because goodwill, they say, is friendship only when it is reciprocated. Perhaps we should add "and recognized"; because people are often well disposed towards persons whom they have never seen, but believe to be

[19] Cf. Plato, *Lysis* 214C.

good or helpful, and one of the latter might feel the same towards the former: then (1156a) clearly these people are well disposed towards each other, but how could we call them friends when their feelings for one another are not known? So friends must be well disposed towards each other, and recognized as wishing each other's good, for one of the three reasons stated above.[20]

iii.

Three kinds of friendship

These reasons differ in kind, and therefore the affections and friendships that they arouse also differ in kind. Consequently there are three kinds of friendship, equal in number to the qualities that arouse love. For there is in each case a kind of mutual affection, known to both parties; and those who love each other wish for each other's good in respect of the quality for which they love them. So those who love each other on the ground of utility do not love each other for their personal qualities, but only in so far as they derive some benefit from each other. Similarly with those who love one another on the ground of pleasure; because it is not for being of a certain character that witty people are liked, but because we find them pleasant. So when people love each other on the ground of utility their affection is motivated by their own good, and when they love on the ground of pleasure it is motivated by their own pleasure; that is, they love the other person not for what he is, but *qua* useful or pleasant. So these friendships are accidental,[21] because the person loved is not loved on the ground of his actual nature, but merely as providing some benefit or pleasure. Consequently such friendships are easily dissolved if the parties do not continue to show the same kind of qualities, because if they cease to be pleasant or useful the friendship comes to an end.

(1) Friendship based on utility

Utility is an impermanent thing: it changes according to circumstances. So with the disappearance of the ground for friendship, the friendship also breaks up, because

[20] 1155b19.

[21] i.e. based on a non-essential ground.

that was what kept it alive. Friendships of this kind seem to occur most frequently between the elderly (because at their age what they want is not pleasure but utility) and those in middle or early life who are pursuing their own advantage. Such persons do not spend much time together, because sometimes they do not even like one another, and therefore feel no need of such an association unless they are mutually useful. For they take pleasure in each other's company only in so far as they have hopes of advantage from it. Friendships with foreigners[22] are generally included in this class.

(2) Friendship based on pleasure

Friendship between the young is thought to be grounded on pleasure, because the lives of the young are regulated by their feelings, and their chief interest is in their own pleasure and the opportunity of the moment. With advancing years, however, their tastes change too, so that they are quick to make and to break friendships; because their affection changes just as the things that please them do, and this sort of pleasure changes rapidly. Also the young are apt to fall in love, for erotic friendship is for the most part swayed by the feelings and based on pleasure. That is why they fall in and out of friendship quickly, changing their attitude often within the same day. But the young do like to spend the day and live together, because that is how they realize the object of their friendship.

(3) Perfect friendship is based on goodness

Only the friendship of those who are good, and similar in their goodness, is perfect. For these people each alike wish good for the other *qua* good,[23] and they are good in themselves. And it is those who desire the good of their friends for the friends' sake that are most truly friends, because each loves the other for what he is, and not for any incidental quality. Accordingly the friendship of such men lasts so long as they remain good; and goodness is an enduring quality. Also each party is good both *absolutely* and *for his friend*, since the good are both good absolutely and useful

[22] Which would normally rest on a business relationship.
[23] Cf. 1156a9–10.

to each other. Similarly they please one another too; for the good are pleasing both absolutely and to each other; because everyone is pleased with his own conduct and conduct that resembles it, and the conduct of good men is the same or similar. Friendship of this kind is permanent, reasonably enough; because in it are united all the attributes that friends ought to possess. For all friendship has as its object something good or pleasant—either absolutely or relatively to the person who feels the affection—and is based on some similarity between the parties. But in this friendship all the qualities that we have mentioned belong to the friends themselves; because in it there is similarity, etc.;[24] and what is absolutely good is also absolutely pleasant; and these are the most lovable qualities. Therefore it is between good men that both love and friendship are chiefly found and in the highest form.

That such friendships are rare is natural, because men of this kind are few. And in addition they[25] need time and intimacy; for as the saying goes, you cannot get to know each other until you have eaten the proverbial[26] quantity of salt together. Nor can one man accept another, or the two become friends, until each has proved to the other that he is worthy of love and so has won his trust. Those who are quick to make friendly advances to each other have the desire to be friends, but they are not unless they are worthy of love and know it. The wish for friendship develops rapidly, but friendship does not.

This kind of friendship, then, is perfect both in point of duration and in all other respects; and in it each party receives from the other benefits that are in all respects the same or similar, as ought to be the case between friends.

iv.

The inferior kinds are less enduring, and are not confined to the good

Friendship for the sake of pleasure has a resemblance to perfect friendship, because good men give each other pleasure; and so does friendship for the sake of utility,

[24] They are alike, and both absolutely and relatively good and pleasant, in themselves and not incidentally.
[25] The friendships.
[26] Apparently a *medimnos* (1.5 bushels!); cf. *Eudemian Ethics* 1238a2. The sense clearly calls for a measure.

because good men are also useful to each other. In these associations too friendships last longest when each receives from the other the same benefit—e.g. pleasure—and not merely that, but from the same source, as in the case of two witty people, and not as in the relation of lover and beloved. For the latter do not take pleasure in the same things: the one finds it in looking at his beloved, and the other in the attentions of his lover. And as beauty wanes, sometimes the friendship wanes too, because the one loses pleasure in the sight, and the other no longer receives the attentions; yet on the other hand many do remain friends if through their intimacy they have come to appreciate each other's characters as being like their own. But when it is not pleasure but gain that lovers exchange in their affairs, their love is less real and less enduring. Those who are friends for the sake of utility part as soon as the advantage ceases, because they were attracted not by each other but by the prospect of gain.

Thus where the object is pleasure or utility friendship is possible between two bad men, or between one good and one bad man, or between one who is neither good nor bad and one who is of any character; but obviously only good men can be friends for their own sakes. For bad people take no pleasure in each other unless there is a chance of some benefit.

Also it is only the friendship of the good that is proof against slander; because it is not easy for a person to take anyone else's word against a friend whom he himself has proved over a long period of time. Between friends like these there are the feelings "I trust him"; "He would never do me wrong"; and all the other conditions that one expects to find in true friendship. But in the other kinds of friendship such things[27] may easily occur. However, since people describe as friends those who are attracted to one another only for reasons of utility, as states are (because it is considered to be for advantage that they form alliances); or of pleasure, as children do; presumably we too should call such people friends, but add that there is more than one kind of friendship, and that friendship in the primary and proper sense is between good men in virtue of their goodness, whereas the rest are friendships only by analogy. For they are friends in so far as they are attracted by a kind of goodness, and by something similar to themselves; because to lovers of pleasure pleasure too is a good. However, these friendships are not very apt to

[27] The slanders etc., mentioned in the context.

coincide; that is, the same people do not become friends for pleasure as well as for utility, because incidental qualities are not often found in pairs.

Now that we have divided friendship into these kinds we shall see that it is persons of low character that are friends on the ground of pleasure or utility, this being the similarity between them; while the good are friends for each other's sake, because their bond is goodness. These latter, then, are friends in the unqualified sense; the others are friends only incidentally and by analogy with them.

v.

Friendship as a state, as an activity and as a feeling

Just as in the case of the virtues some people are called good in respect of a state and others in respect of an activity, so too in the case of friendship. Those who spend their time together enjoy each other's company and confer mutual benefits, but those who are asleep or separated by distance, although they do not express their friendship in action, nevertheless retain the disposition to do so; because distance does not break off a friendship absolutely, but only in its active realization. However, if the absence lasts for a long time it does seem to cause forgetfulness even of the friendship. Hence the saying: "How oft hath silence cut the bond of friendship!" [28]

Neither old people nor sour-tempered ones seem to make friends easily. For there is not much pleasure to be found in them, and nobody can live day after day with someone who annoys him, or even with one who is not agreeable; because nature seems above all things to avoid what is painful and to aim at what is pleasant. Those who approve of each other but do not spend all their time together seem to be well disposed rather than friendly, because nothing is so characteristic of friends as spending time together. (Those who are in need are anxious for help, and even the supremely happy are eager for company, for they above all are least suited by a solitary existence.) But it is impossible for people to live together if they are not agreeable to each other and similar in their tastes, because this seems to be the essence of comradeship.

[28] The source is unknown.

Friendship in the truest sense, then, is friendship between good men, as we have said several times already.[29] For it is accepted that what is lovable and desirable is in general that which is absolutely good or pleasant, while for the individual it is that which is good or pleasant for the individual; and one good man is loved by another on both these grounds.

Affection[30] resembles a feeling, but friendship is a state. For affection can be felt equally well for inanimate objects, but mutual affection involves choice, and choice proceeds from a <moral> state. Also when people wish what is good for those whom they love, for their sake, it is not from a feeling but in accordance with a <moral> state. And in loving a friend they are loving their own good. For when a good man becomes a friend to another he becomes that other's good; so each loves his own good, and repays what he receives by wishing the good of the other and giving him pleasure. There is a saying "caring is sharing",[31] and these qualities belong especially to the friendship of good men.

vi.

Qualified and superficial friendships

Friendships are formed less readily in the case of sour and elderly persons, inasmuch as they are less good-tempered and sociable, and it is just these qualities that are felt to be most amiable and conducive to friendship. This is why the young make friends quickly but the old do not, because people do not make friends with those whose company they do not enjoy. Similarly neither do sour-tempered people. It is true that these types are well disposed to one another, because they wish each other well and meet each other's needs; but they are not really friends, because they do not spend all their time together or enjoy each other's company: things that are considered to be the best evidence of friendly feeling.

[29] 1156b7, 23, 33, 1157a30, b4.
[30] *philēsis.*
[31] Really "friendship is equality"; but this loses the jingling effect of the Greek *philotēs isotēs;* cf. 1168b8.

On the other hand to have many friends in the way of perfect friendship is no more possible than to be in love with many persons at the same time (for love is a kind of excess, and such a feeling is naturally directed towards one person). It is not easy for a large number of people to be attractive at the same time to the same person or (presumably) to be men of good character. Besides, one has to get to know a man thoroughly and become intimate with him, which is extremely difficult. If the basis is utility or pleasure, however, it is possible to be attractive to a number of people, because there are plenty of this type, and such services take little time.

Of these secondary forms of friendship the nearer to true friendship is that which has pleasure for its object, when both parties make the same contribution and enjoy each other's company or the same occupations. The friendships of the young are of this kind, because one finds in them a more generous spirit, whereas utilitarian friendship belongs to the commercially minded. The supremely happy, too, although not needing useful friends, do need agreeable ones; for they want companions of some kind, and although they can put up with unpleasantness for a short time, nobody could endure it continuously—not even the good itself, if he found it unpleasant. So they look for agreeable friends. However, these ought presumably to be good as well, and good *for them*, because then they will have all the qualities that are necessary for a friend. People in high positions, on the other hand, seem to have friends of different types: some are useful to them and others agreeable, but it seldom happens that the same people are both, because what their superiors are looking for is not people who are pleasant and also good, nor people who are useful for honourable ends, but witty talkers if they want to be amused, and otherwise agents who are clever at carrying out their instructions; and these qualities are rarely found in the same person. We have said[32] that the good man is also both useful and agreeable, but such a person does not become the *friend* of a superior in rank unless the latter is his superior in goodness too. Otherwise the inferior cannot make a proportionately equal return.[33] But such goodness is exceptional in the great.

[32] 1156b13–17.
[33] Cf. 1158b23–8, 1162a34–b4.

1158b The friendships of which we have been speaking are based on equality, since both parties receive the same benefits and wish each other the same good, or else exchange one thing for another, e.g. pleasure for help. (We have remarked[34] that these are secondary friendships and comparatively short-lived. Being both like and unlike the same thing, they seem to be friendships in one way but not in another. They appear to be friendships in virtue of their similarity to friendship based on goodness, because one involves pleasure and the other utility, and these are present also in that friendship; but since it is proof against slander and permanent, whereas they are quickly changeable and differ in many other ways, their dissimilarity makes them appear not to be friendship.)

[. . .]

viii.

In friendship loving is more important than being loved

(1159a) Most people seem to want to be loved rather than to love, the reason being their desire for honour.[35] This is why most people are fond of flattery, because a flatterer is a friend of inferior status, or professes to be such, and to love more than he is loved; and to be loved is felt to be the next thing to being honoured, which is the aim of most people. Yet they seem to choose honour not for its own sake, but indirectly. Most people enjoy being held in honour by those in authority because of their expectations; they think that they will get from them anything that they may want, so they enjoy their honour as a token of future favours. But those who are eager for honour from good men who know them have as their object the confirmation of their own opinion of themselves. Thus they enjoy the assurance that they are good men, relying on the judgement of those who tell them so. But people enjoy being loved for its own sake. Hence it may be supposed that being loved is better than being honoured, and that friendship is desirable for its own sake.

But friendship seems to consist more in giving than in receiving affection. An indication of this is the joy that mothers show in loving their children. Some

[34] 1156a16–22.

[35] In the sense of esteem, *timē*.

women give their children to other women to bring up, and although they love them, knowing who they are, do not seek to be loved in return, if it is impossible to have this too; they are content if they see their children getting on well, and they bestow their love upon the children even though the children, through ignorance, make no response such as is due to a mother. So if friendship consists more in loving than in being loved, and if people are commended for loving their friends, it seems that loving is the distinctive virtue of friends. Thus it is when love is given in accordance with merit that people remain friends and their friendship endures. 1159b

This condition offers the best prospect even for unequal parties to be friends, because their inequality can be compensated.[36] The basis of affection is equality[37] and similarity, especially similarity in goodness; because, being steadfast in themselves, they are steadfast also towards each other, and neither require nor render services of a low nature, but virtually preclude them; since it is characteristic of good men neither to go wrong themselves nor to allow their friends to do so. But people of bad character have no constancy, for they do not even remain self-consistent; but they do make temporary friendships, because they enjoy each other's wickedness. The friendships of those who are useful or agreeable are more durable, because they last so long as the friends afford each other pleasure or help. Friendship based on utility seems to occur chiefly between opposite types: e.g. that of a poor man for a rich one, or of an ignoramus for a scholar; because each, being eager to secure what he happens to lack himself, is prepared to give something else in return. One might introduce here the relation between lover and beloved, or between a handsome person and an ugly one. This is the reason why lovers sometimes make themselves look ridiculous by demanding to be loved as much as they love; if they were equally lovable, this would presumably be a reasonable demand, but when they have no such qualification it is ridiculous. The probability is, however, that one opposite is attracted by the other not essentially but incidentally, and the object of the impulse is the mean (because this is good): e.g. the impulse of the dry is not to become wet but to reach the intermediate state; and similarly with the hot and all the rest. But let us dismiss this topic, since in fact it is somewhat irrelevant.

[. . .]

[36] By the inferior's showing greater affection.

[37] Cf. 1157b36.

IX
THE GROUNDS OF FRIENDSHIP

i.
Difficulties caused by differences of motive in friendship

(1163b) In all dissimilar friendships it is, as we have said, a proportion[38] that secures equality
35 and preserves the friendship. E.g. in the relations between citizens: the shoemaker
receives something of equal value in return for his shoes, and so does the weaver
1164a and all the rest. In these cases a common measure is already provided in the shape
of money, and therefore everything is referred to this and is measured by it. But in
emotional relations the lover sometimes complains that his devotion is unrequited
5 (it may be because he has no lovable quality); and often the beloved complains
that the one who used to promise everything now fulfils none of his promises.
Such situations arise when the one loves his beloved on the ground of pleasure and
the other his lover on the ground of utility, and they no longer both possess these
10 attributes; because a friendship based on these motives breaks up as soon as the
reasons for which the friends loved each other no longer present themselves. For
it was not each other that they loved, but each other's attributes, which were not
permanent. Hence friendships of this kind are not permanent either. But friendship
based on character, being disinterested, is lasting, as we have said.[39]

Any breach of contract causes ill-feeling

15 Quarrels occur when the outcome of a friendship is different from what the parties
desire, because failure to obtain what one wants is almost as bad as getting nothing at
all. It is like the story of the man who promised a fee to the harpist, and the better he
played, the higher the fee would be; but when next morning the harpist asked him for

[38] A friendship is dissimilar if the friends differ in quality and make different contributions, e.g. pleasure and profit. The means of equalizing these contributions is not simple proportion (which can only be employed where the contributions are the same in kind), but a sort of diagonal conjunction, as in rectificatory justice; see 1133a5–10.
[39] 1156b17.

what he had promised, he replied that he had already paid him pleasure for pleasure.[40] Now if pleasure had been what both wanted, this would have been satisfactory. But if one wants pleasure and the other gain, and one has his wish and the other does not, the result of the association cannot be fair; for it is what a man actually needs that he 20
is anxious to get, and it is only for its sake that he is prepared to give what he has.

[. . .]

iii.
Grounds for dissolving friendship

Another problem that arises is whether or not to break off friendship with those 1165b
who do not remain the same as they were. Where the bond was one of utility or pleasure there is presumably nothing odd about breaking it when they no longer have these attributes; for it was these that underlay the friendship, and when they fail it is reasonable to feel no affection. But a person might complain if his friend, 5
who liked him only for the profit or pleasure that he got from him, pretended to like him for his character. For (as we said at the outset[41]) most quarrels between friends arise when the basis of their friendship is not what they suppose it to be. When a person is completely mistaken and has assumed that he is loved for his character although his friend has never done anything to suggest it, he has only himself to blame. But when he has been deceived by the other's pretensions he is justified in 10
protesting at the deception—even more than if it had been a case of uttering false coin, since the offence concerns something more valuable than money.

But if A has accepted B as a friend, in the belief that he is a good man, and he turns out or even appears to be a villain, ought A still to love him? Surely this is impossible, assuming that not everything is lovable but only what is good; and it 15
is not right, either, because one ought not to be a lover of what is bad, or to make oneself like a worthless person; and we have said[42] that "like is friend to like".

[40] The harpist had had the pleasure of anticipating a large fee, which was payment enough for the pleasure that he had given. The story was told of Dionysius I of Syracuse (Plutarch, *On the Fortune of Alexander* ii.1).
[41] 1162b23.
[42] 1155a32–6, 1156b19–21, 1159b2–3.

Ought the friendship, then, to be broken off at once? Perhaps not in every case, but only with those whose depravity is incurable. Those who are capable of recovery are entitled to our help for their characters even more than for their fortunes, inasmuch as the character is a higher thing and more closely bound up with friendship. At the same time one who broke off such a friendship would not be felt to be acting oddly, because the man that he made his friend was not like that; so now that he has changed, being unable to restore him to what he was, he gives him up.

But suppose that one friend remains the same, and the other improves and becomes far superior to him in virtue, should he still treat the former as a friend? Surely it is impossible. This appears most clearly in the case of a great disparity, such as occurs in boyhood friendships. Supposing that one person remains a child in intelligence and the other is a man of outstanding ability, how can they go on being friends when they have different interests and different likes and dislikes? They will not even have the same feelings about each other, and without this it is impossible (as we saw[43]) to be friends; because spending their lives together is out of the question. This has been discussed already.

Is one, then, to behave towards a former friend exactly as if he had never been a friend at all? Probably one ought to keep a memory of the former intimacy, and just as we feel bound to show more favour to friends than to strangers, so we should for old acquaintance's sake show some consideration for former friends—provided that the severance was not due to excessive wickedness on their part.

iv.

Our feelings towards our friends reflect our feelings towards ourselves

1166a The friendly feelings that we have towards our neighbours, and the characteristics by which the different kinds of friendship are distinguished, seem to be derived from our feelings towards ourselves. People define a friend as (1) one who wishes and effects the good, or apparent good, of another for the sake of that other; or (2) one who wishes for the existence and preservation of his friend for the friend's sake—the same attitude as mothers have towards their children, or as old friends

[43] 1157b17–24, 1158b33–6.

have towards those with whom they have fallen out. Others define him as (3) one who spends all his time with another, and (4) chooses the same things as he does, or as (5) one who shares his friend's joys and sorrows (this also is a very special trait of mothers). Friendship, too, is defined by one or another of these characteristics. But each one of them applies to the good man in relation to himself (and applies to others in so far as they suppose themselves to be good; in every case, as we have said,[44] the standard seems to be <moral> goodness or the good man). For he is completely integrated[45] and desires the same things with every part of his soul. Also he wishes and effects the things that are or seem to be good for him[46] (for it is the mark of a good man to direct his energies to what is good) and he does it for his own sake (for he does it on account of the intellectual part of him, which is held to be the self of the individual). Also he desires his own life and safety,[47] especially that of his rational part; because for the good man existence is good, and everyone wishes his own good—nobody would choose to have all the good things in the world at the price of becoming somebody else (for as it is the gods possess the good[48]), but only while remaining himself, whatever he is. And it would seem that the thinking part is, or most nearly is, the individual self. Such a person likes his own company,[49] because he enjoys being by himself, since he has entertaining memories of the past and good hopes for the future, and these afford him pleasure; also his mind is well furnished with subjects for contemplation. And he has the fullest consciousness of his joys and sorrows,[50] for it is always the same things that vex or please him, and not different things at different times; because he virtually never changes his mind.

Thus it is because the good man has these several feelings towards himself, and extends to his friend the same relation that he has towards himself (for a friend *is* another self), that friendship is regarded as one of the said feelings, and friends as those to whom these feelings apply. The question whether friendship towards

[44] Cf. 1113a22–33.
[45] He has no inner conflict; see (4) above.
[46] See (1) above.
[47] See (2) above.
[48] And *only* the gods possess the supreme good; so to wish for all good, with a change of personality, would mean wishing to be a god—which is no more sensible than wishing one's friend to be a god (1159a5–12).
[49] See (3) above.
[50] See (5) above.

oneself is possible or not may be dismissed for the present;[51] but it would seem from what we have said that it *is* possible in so far as the subject is regarded as two or more persons; there is also the fact that in its extreme form friendship approximates to self-love.

It seems, however, that the qualities that we have been describing belong also to the majority of people, bad as they are. Probably they share in them only in so far as they are self-satisfied and suppose themselves to be respectable; because nobody who is utterly bad and evil has them, or even the semblance of them. It is hardly too much to say that not even <moderately> bad people have them, because they are in conflict with themselves;[52] they desire one thing and will another, like the incontinent, who choose harmful pleasures instead of what they themselves believe to be good. There are others again who through cowardice and indolence shirk doing what they believe is in their own best interests. Others who have committed many fearful crimes and are hated for their villainy actually run away from life[53] and commit suicide. Also, bad people seek constant companionship and avoid their own society,[54] because when they are by themselves they recall many disagreeable experiences and expect to have more of the same kind, whereas when they are with others they can forget. Possessing no lovable quality, they feel no affection for themselves;[55] consequently such people have no sympathetic consciousness of their own joys and sorrows,[56] because their soul is in a state of conflict: one part of it through depravity feels pain in abstaining from certain things, and another feels pleasure; one pulls this way and the other that, as if they would tear it apart. If it is impossible to feel pleasure and pain at the same time, at any rate such a person is very soon sorry that he was glad, and wishes that he had never taken pleasure in such things; for bad men are full of regrets.

It seems, then, that a bad man is not even amicably disposed towards himself, because he has no lovable quality. So if this state is the height of misery, one ought to strain every nerve to avoid wickedness and try to be a man of good character;

[51] It is taken up explicitly at 1168a28–1169b2.
[52] See (4) above.
[53] See (2) above.
[54] See (3) above.
[55] See (1) above.
[56] See (5) above.

for in that way one can both be on good terms with oneself and become the friend of somebody else.

[. . .]

viii.

Is self-love justifiable?

Another problem is whether one ought to love oneself most or somebody else. (1168a)
People are critical of those whose chief concern is for themselves, and call them self-lovers derogatorily. Also a bad man is generally supposed to do everything from a selfish motive, and to be the more selfish the worse he is (e.g. he is accused of doing nothing unless he has to); whereas the good man acts from a fine motive (and the better the man the finer the motive), and for the sake of a friend, and neglects his own interest. But these theories are not borne out by the facts; nor is this surprising. For they say that a man should love his best friend most. But a man's best friend is the one who not only wishes him well but wishes it for his own sake (even though nobody will ever know it): and this condition is best fulfilled by his attitude towards himself—and similarly with all the other attributes that go to define a friend. For we have said before[57] that all friendly feelings for others are extensions of a man's feelings for himself. Besides, all the proverbial sayings agree on this point: "Two friends, one soul",[58] "Friends share everything", "Caring is sharing",[59] "The knee is nearer than the shin".[60] All these sayings can be applied most aptly to oneself, because a man is his own best friend. Therefore he ought to love himself best. Naturally it is hard to say which of these opinions we should follow, since both have some plausibility.

Presumably, then, we should take such divergent arguments separately and try to distinguish how far and in what way each of them is true. Perhaps the difficulty would be cleared up if we discussed what meaning each side attaches to the word

[57] 1166a1–6.
[58] Euripides, *Orestes* 1046.
[59] Cf. 1157b36.
[60] Cf. Theocritus xvi.18: it is an excuse for selfishness, like "charity begins at home".

self-love. Those who give it a pejorative twist describe as self-loving those who assign themselves the larger share of money, public honours and bodily pleasures, because most people have a craving for these, and set their hearts on them as the greatest goods, which also makes them objects of fierce competition. Well, those who try to get more than their share of these things gratify their desires and their feelings generally, and the irrational part of their soul; and such people are in the majority. Hence the word has become a term of reproach, from the fact that the self-love of most people is a bad thing. Therefore those who are self-lovers in this sense are rightly reproached. And there is no doubt that most people regularly describe as self-lovers those who secure such advantages for themselves. For if anyone made it his constant endeavour to set an example in performing just or temperate or any other kind of virtuous actions, and in general always claimed the prerogative of acting honourably, certainly nobody would reproach *him* with being a self-lover.

Yet such a person might be considered to have a better title to the name. At any rate he assigns to himself what is most honourable and most truly good; and he gratifies the most authoritative part of himself, and obeys it in all respects. And just as in the case of a state or any other composite body the most authoritative part is considered to be most truly the state or body, so too in the case of man.[61] Therefore one who loves this authoritative part and gratifies it is in the truest sense a self-lover. Also a person is called continent or incontinent according as his reason is or is not in control, which implies that this part *is* the individual. Also it is our reasoned acts that are held to be in the fullest sense voluntary and our own doing. Thus there is no doubt that this part is; or most nearly is, the individual man; and that a good man loves it more than anything else. It follows that he will be in the fullest sense a self-lover—but in a different fashion from the man who incurs reproach, and as far superior to him as life ruled by reason is to life ruled by feeling, and as desire for what is fine is to desire for an apparent advantage. Hence those who are exceptionally devoted to the performance of fine actions receive the approval and commendation of all. And if everyone were striving for what is fine, and trying his hardest to do the finest deeds, then both the public welfare would be truly served and each individual would enjoy the greatest of goods, since virtue is of this kind.

So it is right for the good man to be self-loving, because then he will both be

[61] The highest part of him, i.e. the rational part, *is* the man; cf. 1166a17, 22, 1178a2, 7.

benefited himself by performing fine actions and also help others. But it is not right for the bad man, because he will injure both himself and his neighbours by giving way to base feelings. So for the bad man what he ought to do clashes with what he does; but the good man does what he ought to do. For intelligence always chooses what is best for itself, and the good man obeys the guidance of intelligence.

But it is also true to say of the man of good character that he performs many actions for the sake of his friends and his country, and if necessary even dies for them. For he will sacrifice both money and honours and in general the goods that people struggle to obtain, in his pursuit of what is <morally> fine. For he would rather have intense pleasure for a short time than quiet pleasure for a long time; rather live finely for one year than indifferently for many; and rather do one great and glorious deed than many petty ones. This result is presumably achieved by those who give their lives for others; so their choice is a glorious prize. Also the good man is ready to lose money on condition that his friends shall get more; for the friend gets money, but he himself gains fineness <of character>, so he assigns himself the greater good. He behaves in the same way too with regard to political honours and positions; all these he will freely give up to his friend, because that is a fine and praiseworthy thing for him to do. So it is natural that he is regarded as a man of good character, since he chooses what is fine in preference to anything else. He may even give up to his friend opportunities for doing fine actions, and it may be a finer thing for him to become the cause of his friend's doing them than to have done them himself. Thus we see that in the whole field of praiseworthy conduct the good man assigns himself the larger share of what is fine. It is right, then (as we said before[62]), to be self-loving in this sense; but not in the sense in which most people are self-loving.

ix.

Are friends necessary for happiness?

There is a disputable point also with regard to the happy man: whether he will need friends or not. For it is maintained that the supremely happy, who are self-sufficient, have no need of friends, because they have their good things; therefore

[62] 1169a11–15.

being self-sufficient they need nothing further; but a friend, who is "another self", supplies what a man cannot provide by his own efforts. Hence the line "When Fortune smiles on us, what need of friends?"[63]

Yet it seems paradoxical that, while attributing all good things to the happy man, we should not assign him friends, who are considered to be the greatest of external goods. Besides, if it is more characteristic of a friend to confer than to receive a benefit, and doing good to others is characteristic of virtue and the good man, and it is better to do a kindness to a friend than to a stranger, the good man will need friends to receive his benefits. Hence arises a further question: Does one need friends more in prosperity or in adversity? because the unfortunate need people to be kind to them, and the fortunate need people to be kind to.

It is also surely paradoxical to represent the man of perfect happiness as a solitary; for nobody would choose to have all the good things in the world by himself, because man is a social creature[64] and naturally constituted to live in company. Therefore the happy man also has this quality, because he possesses everything that is naturally good; and it is clearly better to spend one's time in the company of friends and good men than in that of strangers and people of uncertain character. It follows, therefore, that the happy man needs friends.

What, then, is the meaning of those who uphold the first view,[65] and what truth is there in their arguments? Perhaps the answer is that in the popular view our friends are those who are useful to us; so the truly happy man will have no need of such people, since he already has the things that are good for him. Nor indeed will he require friends on the ground of pleasure, or only to a limited extent, because his life is pleasant and needs no imported pleasure; and since he does not need friends of these kinds he is thought to need none at all. But this is presumably not true. For it was stated at the outset[66] that happiness is a kind of activity; and an activity clearly is developed and is not a piece of property already in one's possession. Now if happiness consists in living and being active, and the activity of a good

[63] Euripides, *Orestes* 667.
[64] Cf. 1097b11.
[65] That the happy man needs no friends (1169b4–8).
[66] 1098a7, 16, b31–1099a7.

man is virtuous and pleasurable in itself (as we said at the outset[67]); and if we take pleasure in what is our own; and if we are better able to observe our neighbours than ourselves, and their actions than our own; and if the actions of high-minded[68] men who are our friends are pleasant to the good (because both attributes are naturally pleasant[69]): then it follows that the truly happy man will need friends of this sort, because he prefers to contemplate actions that are honourable and his own, and the actions of a good man who is his friend are of this nature. Besides, it is assumed that the happy man ought to enjoy living. Now a solitary man has a hard life, because it is not easy to keep up a continuous activity by oneself; but in company with others and in relation to others it is easier. Consequently the activity, which is pleasant in itself, will be more nearly continuous, as the truly happy man's ought to be (for the good man *qua* good enjoys actions that are in accordance with virtue, but is disgusted by those that proceed from wickedness, just as a musician likes beautiful music but is irritated by what is bad). Also a sort of training in virtue may result from associating with good people, as Theognis says.[70]

But if we look at the question more scientifically it appears that a good friend is by nature desirable for a good man. For (as we have said before)[71] what is by nature good is in itself good and pleasant to the good man. Now the life of animals is defined by the capacity for sensation, and that of man by the capacity for sensation or thinking. But this capacity is relative to its activity, and its realization depends upon the activity. Hence it appears that to live is primarily to perceive or to think. But to live is one of the things that are in themselves good and pleasant, for it is determinate,[72] and what is determinate is of the nature of the good.[73] Now what is good by nature is also good for the good man, and therefore appears pleasant in the eyes of all. We must not take the case of a vicious and corrupt life, or of one that is

[67] 1099a14, 21.
[68] *spoudaios*.
[69] As being both good and virtually one's own.
[70] Theognis 25; the words are quoted at 1172a13–14.
[71] 1099a7–11, 1113a25–31.
[72] i.e. something of which we have a clear conception and which is capable of full development or actualization.
[73] Cf.1106b30.

passed in suffering, because such a life is indeterminate, just as are the conditions that attach to it. (The question of pain will be made clearer in the sequel.[74]) But assume the following propositions;[75] (1) Life is in itself good and pleasant (as appears from the fact that it is sought after by all, especially by those who are virtuous and truly happy, because their life is in the highest degree desirable, and their existence the truest felicity). (2) A man who sees is aware that he is seeing, a man who hears that he is hearing and a man who walks that he is walking; and similarly in all our other activities there is something that is aware of them, so that if we perceive, we perceive that we are perceiving, and if we think, that we are thinking. (3) To be conscious that we are perceiving or thinking is to be conscious of our existence (for we saw[76] that existence is sensation or thought). (4) To be conscious that one is alive is something pleasant in itself (because life is by nature good, and to be conscious that one possesses a good thing is pleasant). (5) Life is a desirable thing, especially for the good, because for them existence is good and pleasant (since they feel pleasure in the consciousness of what is in itself good). (6) The good man feels towards his friend as he feels towards himself, because his friend is a second self to him. If all this is true, it follows that for a given person the existence of his friend is as desirable, or almost as desirable, as his own. But as we saw,[77] what makes existence desirable is the consciousness of one's own goodness, and such consciousness is pleasant in itself. So a person ought to be conscious[78] of his friend's existence, and this can be achieved by living together and conversing and exchanging ideas with him—for this would seem to be what living together means in the case of human beings; not being pastured like cattle in the same field.

If, then, to the truly happy man his own existence is desirable in itself, as being by nature good and pleasant, and if the existence of his friend is scarcely less so, then his friend must also be a thing desirable.[79] But what is desirable for him he must have, or else fall short of happiness in that respect. Therefore to be happy a man will need virtuous friends.

[74] But it is not.
[75] For clarity a long and involved Greek period has been broken up into separate sentences in the translation.
[76] 1170a16–17.
[77] 1170b4–5.
[78] By sympathetic insight, not outwardly through the senses.
[79] Strictly "choosable" *(hairetos)*, i.e. rightly desirable.

x.

How many friends should one have?

Should one, then, make as many friends as possible? Or, as the poet has said—aptly, it is thought—on the subject of hospitality, "Neither let many share thy board, nor none",[80] will it be the right thing in friendship too to be neither friendless nor, on the other hand, excessively supplied with friends? The principle quoted above would seem to be absolutely the right one in the case of utilitarian friends, for returning the services of a large number of people is a laborious task which life is too short to accomplish. So more friends than are enough to fulfil our own lives are superfluous and a hindrance to living in the right way: therefore there is no need for them. Also a few friends for amusement are quite enough, like a pinch of seasoning in food. But with regard to friends of good character: ought we to have as many as possible numerically, or is there a limit to the number of friends, as there is to the population of a city?[81] —for one cannot have a city with ten people and with 100,000 it would no longer be a city.[82] Presumably there is no one correct number, but anything between certain limits. So also there is a limit to the number of one's friends; and probably this would be the largest number with whom one can be on intimate terms—because this, as we saw,[83] is the chief factor in friendship—and it is not hard to see that one cannot be intimate, and share oneself, with a large number of people. Besides, they too must be friends with one another, if they are all to live as a group; and it is difficult to have this state of affairs when the numbers are large. It becomes difficult even to sympathize closely with the joys and sorrows of many, because one is likely to be faced with sharing the joy of one and the sorrow of another simultaneously. Probably, then, it is as well to aim at having not as many friends as possible, but only as many as are enough to form an intimate circle. Indeed it would seem to be impossible to be the devoted friend of many, for the same reason that one cannot be in love with more than one; because by love we mean an extreme affection, and this is felt towards *one* person; therefore strong friendship too is felt only towards a few. This seems to be the case in actual life.

[80] Hesiod, *Works and Days* 660.
[81] Cf. *Politics* 1326a35–b25.
[82] i.e. a properly integrated community.
[83] 1157b19.

We do not find that friendships amounting to comradeship are formed by many people: the celebrated cases are reported as occurring between two.[84] Those who have a great many friends and greet everybody familiarly are felt to be friends of nobody (except in the sense that fellow-citizens are friends): the sort of people that are called obsequious.[85] It is possible, indeed, to be friendly with many in the civic sense and not be obsequious—in fact to be a man of really admirable character; but it is not possible to have many friends whom we love for their own sake and for their goodness; we must be content to find even a few of this quality.

[. . .]

xii.

The value of friendly intercourse

(1171b) Are we to say, then, that just as lovers find the keenest satisfaction in seeing, and prefer this sense to all the others, because they feel that it is the source and stay of love, so to friends there is nothing more desirable than spending their lives together? For friendship is a kind of partnership, and a man stands in the same relation to his friend as to himself, and since the consciousness of his own existence is desirable, the consciousness of his friend's must be the same; and this consciousness becomes actualized in their life together, so that they naturally desire it. Also everyone wishes to share with his friends the occupation (whatever it is) that constitutes his existence, or makes life worth living. This is why some drink together, others dice together, others go in for athletics and hunting together or for philosophy, each type spending their time together in the pursuit that gives them most satisfaction in their lives; indeed in their desire to spend their lives with their friends they follow these pursuits and share in them as much as possible. Consequently the friendship of worthless people has a bad effect (because they take part, unstable as they are, in worthless pursuits, and actually become bad through each other's influence).

[84] e.g. Theseus and Pirithous, Achilles and Patroclus, Orestes and Pylades, etc. (Plutarch, *On Having Many Friends* 93E).

[85] Cf. 1126b11–14.

But the friendship of the good is good, and increases in goodness because of their association. They seem even to become better men by exercising their friendship and improving each other; for the traits that they admire in each other get transferred to themselves. Hence the saying "From good men goodness . . .".[86]

So much for our account of friendship. Our next subject for discussion will be pleasure.

[86] Theognis 35, alluded to at 1170a12.